

June 7, 2026

Dear Vista Board Chair and Directors:

Vista Charter School was strategically created in 2009 as a pioneering choice in public education with the innovative use of technology and an emphasis on an education in the arts as an interdisciplinary experience. Over the past 17 years, Vista has become the premier place for arts-and-technology education for students K thru 9 in Southern Utah. Our school is sought out by families because of its elite arts-and-technology educators and the program culture they have created. Thousands of students have excelled under the tutelage of these dedicated mentors. Notably, current Vista students and alumni are achieving great success in the form of scholarships, professional opportunities, and entry into competitive programs. Beyond the accolades, all students in every discipline benefit from these caring mentors who teach beyond the subjects of arts and technology to include transferable life skills, such as collaboration, leadership, communication, confidence, teamwork, friendship, working with others who see things differently than themselves, etc.

That said, as parents, we are concerned for the future of Vista's arts department. In recent years, Vista's arts department has had several teachers leave because of non-renewal of contract or to move on to other opportunities. At the end of the 2025–26 school year, three additional arts educators are leaving Vista: Linda DeLuca (orchestra), Jake Thomas (theater), and Madeline Haskett (dance). The loss of these educators/mentors follows a stream of other arts educators and staff over the past five years—constituting a turnover of more than 40% in the arts department at Vista. (See attached list.) The optics of having a significant turnover of our performing arts educators and staff, especially when coupled with the absence of any performing-arts director/liaison among the current five-person administration team, does not support Vista's charter, which has a stated focus on the arts. (See *7 Charter School Purposes*, Vista at Entrada 2009 Charter School Application, pp. 6–8.)

Among the *7 Charter School Purposes* included in Vista's charter application is a section dedicated to parental involvement in management decisions at the school level. Page 26 of the charter shows an organizational flow chart that encourages parental involvement on board committees. As such, in past years, the Vista Board has had committees designated for parent involvement in student excellence, specifically regarding arts, technology, and academics. However, Vista currently does not have an active arts committee advising the board. **Ahead of the 2026-27 school year, we request that the board again create a collaborative arts committee composed of parents, educators, administrator(s), and a sitting board member.** This committee would specifically serve to support Vista's arts team, provide needed insights to the

board, and help preserve the integrity of the existing arts programs and growth within the arts department.

Although the arts are vital to the mission and charter of Vista School, it appears that these programs have had diminishing support from the administration and board over the past several years. Decisions regarding the arts program have seemingly been made solely based on economic measures without crucial teacher and parent input. **As concerned parents, we ask that the Vista Board address the status and plan for Vista's arts programs as an agenda item at its upcoming June 15 meeting.** Attached are questions that we would like discussed at that meeting.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

Concerned Vista Families

Hillary Osness	Melissa Webb	Siham Butler
Roger Osness	Mathew Webb	Sarah Sanders
Katie Pearce	Erin Hafen	Mark Sanders
Darren Pearce	Lisa Wood	Whitney Guglietti
Megan Milne	Ronny Wood	Gabe Guglietti
Eli Milne	Sierra Aybar	Stephanie Jaeger
Elise Hurst	Erik Aybar	Maria Serrata
Ezra Hurst	Caitlin Skillings	Char Macurdy
Heather Robinson	York Skillings	Joel Robertson
Annie Ashton	Jenny Ballantyne	Summer Robertson
Adam Ashton	Spencer Ballantyne	Amber Gillette
Heather Braden	Monica Diaz	Chanae Cantrell
Kim Clegg	Saul Cruz	Skyler Cantrell
Russ Clegg	Vanessa Cruz	Natalia Herrera
Alejandra Klc	John Gubler	Ricardo A. Cureno
Stacie Hall	Kathy Gubler	Brittani Terry
Tyler Hall	Abigail Pearson	Lesa Iverson
Leslie Jacobs	Amber Hann	Radlee Iverson
Jim Jacobs	Sara Bostwick	Nacolynn Tanielu
Mimi Knell	Angela Timms	Rebekah Rogers
Howard Church	Chad Timms	Natalie Spring
Steffanie Church	Anna Mae Jorgensen	Matthew Spring
Jared Gough	Rob Seaman	Rachel Wittig
Kathy Gough	Wendy Seaman	Anthony Wittig
Julie Flowers	Stephanie Hamberlin	Kim Wilks
Kilee Adams	Joseph Jeppson	Ken Wilks
Wes Adams	Fabiola Soto	

Discussion questions regarding the future of Vista's arts program

1. Arts Advocacy: Who on the admin team will fill the role of performing arts director/advocate for Vista School? How will the admin support the arts going forward to preserve the integrity of the charter? Who will fill this role of arts advocacy/oversight on the Vista Board?
2. Jake Thomas played an integral role as stage manager and technical director for Vista's numerous productions. With the countless productions at Vista throughout the year, this is an extremely time-intensive position. (i.e. assemblies as well as tech & dress rehearsals and performances for every performing arts program: orchestra, guitar, piano, dance, MDT companies, theater, etc.) Any time lights and sound are required, Jake Thomas was the one who performed these tasks, in addition to creating the majority of the light and sound designs for each unique performance. How will Vista fill this vital position?
3. With the non-renewal of Jake Thomas' contract, who will be taking over the theater and tech theater classes, VRS, middle school play, etc.? If another teacher is not hired, will there be a decrease in theater class offerings?
4. Has an orchestra teacher been found to replace Linda DeLuca? Will there be a change in orchestra offerings for the upcoming school year? Could a new orchestra teacher also teach band classes to bring that option back to the Vista community?
5. In addition to elective offerings, how are the arts integrated into learning instruction as indicated in the charter?
6. For the 2025-26 School year it was difficult for 6th grade students who were not in an auditioned dance company to be admitted to a dance class because older students were given priority for elective choices. This limits artistic growth for students coming from the elementary school dance classes. There is an abundance of interest in the dance program. How is the administration addressing this need?
7. How are the arts programs funded? For example, do the proceeds from ticket sales stay within its appropriate arts department (e.g. Nutcracker - Dance Company; Middle School Musical - Theater/VRS?) Do the directors have oversight and/or discretion on how the excess budget money (ie. primarily from parent-paid ticket sales) is used?

Detail of Attrition of Vista Arts Department over the past 5 years

- Band Director Chris Clegg left in 2022 when electives for 4th and 5th graders were cut from 4 electives to 2 electives. Mr. Clegg was in the early years of building a successful band program and was forced to leave Vista to provide for his family because Vista wouldn't offer him an option for a full-time position.
- Elementary Art and Music Educator Kathy Carlson departed in 2024. She is beloved by all - even by those who didn't continue to pursue arts or music electives after third grade.
- Choir Director Abe Nickle left in 2024. He was instrumental to the vocal program at Vista including auditioned performing groups.
- Performing Arts Coordinator Julie Fonseca left in October 2024. This position was not filled until Spring 2025, leaving the Performing Arts team without needed support during busy performing seasons, including the Nutcracker and Middle School Musical.
- In 2025, The Vista Board eliminated the band program at Vista and lost the part-time band director. Parents with children in the program were not part of the decision making process that left their kids without a favorite elective.
- There is also turnover in the dance department (Jennie Jones, Olivia Thomas, and now Madeline Haskett). Our VCE programs work in tandem with the growing dance program to train emerging dancers. Vista's dance program has more than 200 students involved and not enough teachers to fill the increasing need.
- Former Admin Kelly Geary was not only admin/learning coach she also served as the Performing Arts director/liaison for the administration. Losing her in 2024 was a significant loss to the advocacy of the arts at the administrative level.

Sections of Vista Charter for Reference

Vista's full Charter document is posted on the [Vista Policies and Forms](#) page and is listed under the Board-Specific section.

Continue to improve student learning. Continuous improvement of student learning will be an ongoing goal and purpose of Vista School. Our approach to improvement of student learning is based on three pillars: exposure to the arts, increased use of technology, and empowerment of the teaching staff.

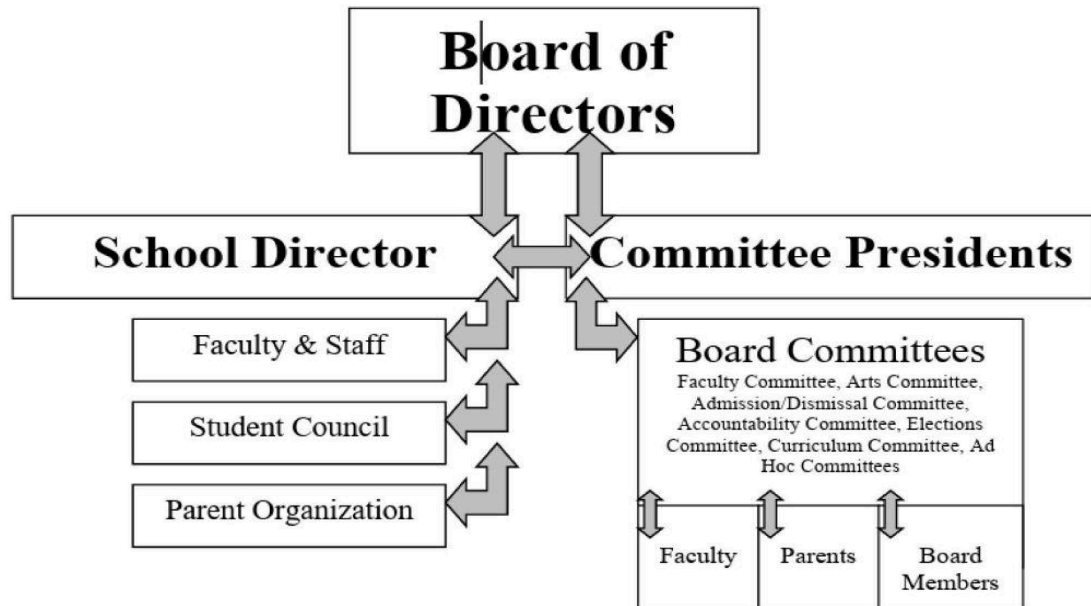
Exposure to the Arts. The first pillar focuses on research-based philosophy indicating that students can attain higher levels of achievement through their engagement with the arts. Further research has shown that learning in and through the arts can help “level the playing field” for students from disadvantaged circumstances. We will integrate instruction in an arts-rich environment with a robust and research-based curriculum to improve student learning at Vista School. Vista School's program will enable students to have direct involvement with the arts and artists, encourage self-directed learning, engage community leaders and resources, and require significant staff development.

Provide greater opportunities for parental involvement in management decisions at the school level. The most substantive way for parents to be involved in the operation and management of Vista School is through service on Vista School's Board of Directors or a Vista School Committee. Vista School's Board of Directors consists of parents and community leaders that have a desire to serve the interests of the school. The Board of Directors is charged with managing the property, affairs, and overall operation of the school. In addition, the Board of Directors establishes and enforces Vista School policy to ensure the school operates in a manner consistent with Vista School's mission, its charter, and all applicable laws. Although board membership is limited, parents will have other meaningful opportunities to be involved in management decisions. For example, each Vista School committee will have at least one parent member. By serving on Vista School committees, parents will be involved in more specific areas that might involve less commitment or focus on more specific issues (e.g. legal, education, accounting). This will allow parent volunteers to donate their time more efficiently and still have a strong influence on policy and management decisions. Other opportunities for parental involvement will include voicing opinions at regularly scheduled public board meetings, responding to parent/student questionnaires, and actively participating in the elections of new board members. (*7 Charter School Purposes*, Vista at Entrada 2009 Charter School Application, p6-7.)

Special Emphasis

Vista seeks to be a pioneering choice in public education, empowering students through a dynamic partnership between a rich and research-based curriculum, the innovative use of technology, and an emphasis on an education in the arts as an interdisciplinary experience. By providing students with an excellent education, grounded in high academic standards, as well as meaningful encounters with all arts mediums, Vista will create a nurturing environment for students who have a strong interest in academics and the arts. (Vista at Entrada 2009 Charter School Application, p33)

Organizational Flow Chart



(Vista at Entrada 2009 Charter School Application, p26)